

Speaker 1 [00:00:01] First of all, do you agree to participate in this study in accordance with the consent form I sent to you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:08] Yes .

Speaker 1[00:00:09] Okay. First of all, I'm going to ask you a few demographic questions. How old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:14] [20-25].

Speaker 1 [00:00:15] [20-25]. How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:00:20] [1-5] years.

Speaker 1 [00:00:22] [1-5] years. Do you have children?

Speaker 2 [00:00:26] No.

Speaker 1 [00:00:28] Who do you live with at home?

Speaker 2 [00:00:30] I live alone.

Speaker 1 [00:00:33] What is your main source of income?

Speaker 2 [00:00:37] [Occupation].

Speaker 1[00:00:38] [Occupation]. What would you like us to call your partner? Partner, lover, girlfriend.

Speaker 2 [00:00:46] It doesn't matter, all of them are suitable for me.

Speaker 1 [00:00:48] Okay. I'm going to ask questions in a romantic context. Can you tell me the story of how you met and how your relationship started?

Speaker 2 [00:00:59] Sure. We were actually following each other on [Social Media] for a long time, but we never had any communication. We were following each other without meeting. I didn't even know that she was a lesbian, I had never paid that kind of attention. Then I actually messaged her as a friend to sit down. Because the things she shared in her stories drew my attention. But then things progressed differently in the process we talked and we had a flirtation period of [<1 year]. Then our marriage started.

Speaker 1 [00:01:30] So for example, why did these posts attract your attention? I mean, was it because of something in common? Or you know, what was the point that attracted your attention in these posts?

Speaker 2 [00:01:41] Yes, yes. I mean, I am a person who likes to travel a lot. Restaurants, cafes and so on. She was also a person who traveled a lot and I learned that she used to be a photographer. That's why the quality of the photos she shared was very high and I was very surprised, you know, on Instagram because I had never seen such good content taken with a phone camera. I thought she took them with a camera. Actually, that's where the conversation started. I mean, I was very interested. I mean, I see worse with my own eyes, she sees better. Actually, I can say that I was interested in her common interests and the fact that she shares such nice things.

Speaker 1 [00:02:17] So, for example, what were the points that changed your relationship from a friendship to a flirtation for you?

Speaker 2 [00:02:26] Honestly, I think it was when I realized that she was lesbian. Because I didn't really look at it from that point of view. There are also very stereotypes like that, she wasn't someone who fit stereotypes very much in terms of appearance, but when she talked, I could understand more. When that happened, I started to wonder a little bit, because we communicate very often, we talk in the morning, we talk in the evening and so on. Afterwards, I wondered if it would be a little bit like that. Anyway, it switched from friendship to flirting very quickly, and on the other hand, she made a joke like you are my third flirt or something like that. After that, it was like we were flirting at that moment, actually a little bit more, but I was already acting interested, so that's what happened. We had such a transition.

Speaker 1 [00:03:14] So how would you evaluate the quality of your relationship compared to your friends' relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:03:21] Well, I think it is of better quality because I am in a relationship with a woman for the first time in my life. Before that, I had many relationships with many men. I have been dating since I was very young. I don't know if I can use it instead of dating, but when I look at my friends in general, first of all, I think there is a different kind of empathy that comes from being two women. We can feel the same emotions. Having a girlfriend after telling a boyfriend about the situation I'm going through is much more helpful for me in this regard. Because she understands from a glance. Apart from that, we can have much more common interests. And of course, we women do not have as high energy as men due to hormonal balances. But I see this in the relationships of my friends. The male side is very energetic and wants to go out and do something even after a very tiring working day, while women are already tired. Maybe it's her menstrual period, something happens and she wants to rest, but I think we know how to balance this more easily in a homosexual relationship. When we want to rest, we both want to rest, when we want to do something, we both do it. That's why I think we are more socially, how should I say, harmonious. So we have such a difference.

Speaker 1 [00:04:34] Well, for example, you mentioned empathy, can you give concrete examples of this in your answer?

Speaker 2 [00:04:41] I mean like this. For example, I went through a process where my parents got divorced. I have been going through a period of ebb and flow for about [1-5] years. At the beginning of this process, I had a boyfriend with whom I had been together for a very long time, about [6-10] years. Although he knew me, he couldn't understand my reactions to events, for example. He always had an attitude that you exaggerate too much, you dramatize everything too much, but I don't know. I guess girls are a little more attached to their families, so now, for example, my girlfriend can understand me very easily, even though a lot of time has passed since the incident, I still react as if it were new. For example, she says, "Yes, I know why you feel like this". Sometimes I have problems with my friends." While I have always received a reaction from my boyfriends like "This is friendship, it's like this, today it's here, tomorrow it's gone", for my girlfriend now, since her friends are very important to her as they are to me, she can understand the points where I am offended much more clearly, for example, or I don't need to explain it very long. For example, I just tell her about the incident and she can say that I am offended without expressing my feelings. So there is such empathy between us.

Speaker 1 [00:05:57] Can I also ask how many romantic relationships you had in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:06:03] It has stopped.

Speaker 1 [00:06:06] Can you hear me now? Can you hear me now?

Speaker 2 [00:06:12] Uh, yes, I can hear it now, but it's freezing again. Because the image... Yes, yes I can hear it.

Speaker 1 [00:06:18] Okay can I ask you how many romantic relationships have you had in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:06:28] [1-5] I think yes [1-5].

Speaker 1 [00:06:30] [1-5]. Okay. And how would you rate the quality of your current relationship compared to your previous relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:06:39] I think like I just said it's much better quality because we can spend more, I don't know, quality time. We are really doing an activity and I used to feel that there was more sexual pressure in my relationships with men. For example, although I actually wanted to have so much sexuality, of course, I felt such pressure due to structural differences and there was such a point in the relationship that I was uncomfortable, but now, for example, I don't feel that and this really increases the quality of the relationship. At the moment, there is a sexuality when both parties want it. First of all, there is already such a big difference. As I just mentioned, there is a huge emotional difference. Being able to get along much more easily, it feels like we are speaking the same language. And again, because our interests are similar, we can do different, more beautiful things together. When I had boyfriends, it was just about going out for dinner, sitting with our friends and coming home. With my current girlfriend, we enjoy board games a lot and when they are on sale, we buy one and play it, we do puzzles, we do Legos, we have interests like that, but I have never experienced such things in my previous relationships with men, for example.

Speaker 1 [00:08:01] Well, for example, you said that you spend much more quality time, this quality time...

Speaker 2 [00:08:08] Wait a second, I missed you completely.

Speaker 1 [00:08:12] Okay. Is it better now?

Speaker 2 [00:08:21] Were you able to hear what I was saying? Because there was a very long disconnect.

Speaker 1 [00:08:25] Yes. I heard, I heard, can you hear me now?

Speaker 2 [00:08:30] Okay you repeat your question. Yes yes I can hear you.

Speaker 1 [00:08:33] Okay. For example, in your answer you talked about spending more quality time and you talked about having similar interests. Can you give concrete examples of that?

Speaker 2 [00:08:48] For example, we love to cook together. We find a different recipe and try it. It's a bit more challenging. We really enjoy building Legos. We are always working on a project. We spread around the house and build Legos. Sometimes it's puzzle-type things, board games, sometimes it's card games like Monopoly, Uno or something like that. Or even cleaning the house is a lot of fun. I do something while she does something else, and in the meantime it becomes fun. We actually have hobbies that we do together like this in our daily life.

Speaker 1 [00:09:24] So what are the elements that make a relationship high quality for you?

Speaker 2 [00:09:29] For me, if communication is not healthy. I mean, getting out of toxicity, not discussing the same topic 45 times, for example. So when there is a problem, we talk about it 5 times at most. If it is a serious problem, it is very important for me to be able to solve it. Spending time together not as a duty but really willingly is something that determines the quality of the relationship for me, I think these two are the two main elements.

Speaker 1 [00:10:05] So can you tell us a little bit more about, for example, how a person can recognize when they are in a healthy communication?

Speaker 2 [00:10:14] I mean, first of all, it is important for me that the voice does not get too loud. Because shouting makes you feel bad and it doesn't really solve anything. Because this time the anger increases a lot. So first of all this. Secondly, how can I say this? Her real problem is that she is trying to express what she is. Because sometimes this happens a lot in couples, there is a problem in the middle, but instead of expressing it directly, there is a behavior like flogging a dead horse, so to speak, some jealousy problems that have been experienced in the past and talked

about forty times. Instead of that, no, this is the problem I'm having right now and I'm talking about it. I'm reheating something from the past and presenting it to you, or diverting the subject and making the other person uncomfortable and pushing them to apologize. Things like that are unhealthy for me. I mean direct communication, open communication, where both people can express their feelings openly, sometimes it's appropriate. Yes, I'm jealous right now. Yes, I'm angry right now. Even though they may find it ridiculous, for example, they can say it openly to the other party. I think this means healthy communication for me.

Speaker 1 [00:11:38] So you mentioned the time spent together willingly at home, when did you want it the most or when did you feel it the least in your relationship, when did you feel that even the other person was less willing to spend time willingly?

Speaker 2 [00:12:00] In the summer months. For example, I felt it last summer. [Partner's Name] is working and I'm not working. I'm preparing for my master's degree, so I already have a lot of free time. But since I was so used to her working, it was better for me to miss her until the evening or to be able to see her a few days a week, that is, to have a time when I missed her, a time when I had things to tell her about. But in the summer months, her job became very relaxed. That's why we were able to spend a lot of time together. She took her annual leave, and even though we were actually exploring a new place during that time, even though we went on vacation, being together all the time made me tired. Because we also stayed with my family, we were more like friends there, not like lovers. And that in itself is a stress factor. But apart from that, having breakfast together, spending the whole day together and spending the evening together frankly tired me out. So I can say that not having a separate time bored me more.

Speaker 1 [00:13:10] So to summarize this question, can we say that high quality relationships are relationships where there is healthy communication and where you spend time together willingly?

Speaker 2 [00:13:19] Yes, yes I agree.

Speaker 1 [00:13:21] Actually, you answered this a little bit in the previous question, but since it is the main topic of our project, I would like to ask a little bit more, with your permission, what are the most important things in a relationship for you?

Speaker 2 [00:13:37] As I mentioned again, open communication, being able to spend quality time together and also being there for each other in difficult and good times in each other's lives. Because some people can be jealous of good achievements and sometimes they want to suppress them. So I think it's good to be able to share good times and positive developments. Apart from

that, there may be mourning, there may be loss. I think it is very valuable for your partner to be with you in such processes. I think these are the main points.

Speaker 1 [00:14:18] So what is love for you?

Speaker 2 [00:14:22] For me love..it is a very different question. I think it's something in that class where you can place a person between friends and family, where I love (sevmek) them a little more than my friends, I value them a little more, but they are not exactly in my family. But a person you can put first priority in your life. When someone else says let's meet, when you say that no, I have a program with my partner, I think a love (aşk) has emerged. Because it is one click ahead of other people for you. But I don't agree with the part about butterflies in your heart or something like that, so it's not such a big emotional explosion, but just seeing her excites people, for example, you know, I agree with her, I definitely agree with her, around that person, people try to be more well-groomed, try to look more beautiful, sometimes try to show themselves a click better than they are. I think you fall in love with her because of things like that.

Speaker 1 [00:15:35] So how important do you think love is in a relationship? Can you hear me right now? Can you hear me right now?

Speaker 2 [00:16:09] Right now I've changed my internet and yes let me take the question again, I apologize very much.

Speaker 1 [00:16:14] No, not at all. How important do you think love is in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:16:22] Sir?

Speaker 1 [00:16:24] How important do you think love is in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:16:27] I mean I would say seventy percent. Because there are definitely relationships where there is no love but there is trust. Some people prefer to have a relationship of logic, for economic or social reasons. I mean, we can't say that they are not relationships either, but of course, I think a relationship where there is love is much more beautiful. So if there are other bonds of trust and love (sevgi) on top of that, I think seventy percent is important.

Speaker 1 [00:17:00] Okay. So how do you know if your partner loves you?

Speaker 2 [00:17:08] I know when they do things that make me happy. I mean, how can I say sometimes, of course, when she makes sacrifices, then I say that she definitely loves me a lot. But of course, we live a normal life, we don't need such a big sacrifice, but just little things to make me happy. For example, buying something I mentioned and I like, for example, or wanting to go somewhere I want to go, or being there for me when I'm not feeling well. So I know that she loves me when she does things like that to make me feel better.

Speaker 1 [00:17:45] So can you give concrete examples of this? Or that you have experienced in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:17:54] I mean, for example, the one that sticks in my mind the most right now is that I wanted to celebrate our anniversary with our friends, not alone, because we hardly get together with our friends and they have a big role in our relationship and they were always with us. You know, we have such a crowded social group because I actually wanted to celebrate with them but the date never coincided. I was going to be abroad on that date and I came back from abroad. I got off the plane, she came to pick me up from the airport and said that she would drop me off at a friend's house, that she had put clothes and towels there for me, that I should take a shower there, get ready and come home. And when you get home I'll be ready and we'll go out together. But when I came home, they had gathered all our friends at home and set a big table and we sat down and celebrated our anniversary in this way, which we never planned, and she did it during a very busy work period. I can actually see the sacrifice here, but that was just a sentence that came out of my mouth. It didn't have to be like this. We didn't have to celebrate anyway. But the fact that she made such a big organization for me to be happy made me feel really loved (sevildiğimi).

Speaker 1 [00:19:10] Well, for example, in your sentence, you said that the labor of your friends was a lot in your relationship, could you tell us more about this part?

Speaker 2 [00:19:18] Well, first of all, as I mentioned, I had never been in a relationship with a woman before, but I had a very close gay friend and of course, because of him, gay relationship was something I was very familiar with. But when I met [Partner's Name], I actually had the opportunity to get ideas and encouragement from that friend. She made such a contribution to us. In addition to her, I had some friends from school, and I don't want to say that some of them are homophobic, but foreign homophobia and lack of knowledge are two different things, lack of knowledge, and even something that one can accept is actually not normalized. Because they haven't seen or heard it. This is different. I don't think there is hatred in this, there is ignorance. Actually, I thought they would be a bit like that and this made me nervous. My friends are at my socio-economic level, we studied at the same school, we share similar circles, and if I am so afraid



of their reaction, what am I going to do against the rest of the society? I mean, am I going to keep it a secret for life, but my friends were incredibly supportive and they took [Partner's Name], no, I can't even say giving her a chance, directly into their circle. They established a great intimacy with her. Or when I had some difficulties, when we argued, they were always there for me to solve things. Because they trusted our relationship very well, very much. I mean, they also thought that we had a very good relationship. So they have such labor.

Speaker 1 [00:21:00] Well, in this context, if I may, I would like to ask the following, but if it is a more difficult subject for you to talk about, feel free to tell me. You know, especially in a country like [Country], for example, having such a relationship, what do you think are the disadvantages and advantages of having a gay relationship, what have you experienced?

Speaker 2 [00:21:24] I mean, yes, it's a subject that can be talked about for a very long time, but I don't mind talking about it, by the way. I mean I was born and raised in the [Region] and I was actually in a more modern environment and my mother had the lack of knowledge part of what I just mentioned, but I never saw homophobia in my father because my father had a shop in a resort town and that was in [Municipality] and there are incredibly many gays there and everyone was experiencing it very openly. I mean, at least when I was a kid and at that time it was something that was very normalized for us and my father stopped me one day and said. Look, these two men holding hands, they love each other, there is no need for gender for two people to love each other, two people can just find love and love each other and have a relationship, you will never find it strange for the rest of your life. This is something that has stayed with me from childhood and I think about it and I say how lucky I am compared to other people. But my mother was a little more prejudiced. Because she never heard or knew it in her surroundings, she grew up in a very small place. But you know, I always thought that I don't have to explain them right now. You know, things will progress further, we will decide to live in the same house or something. In that case, I thought I would explain to her, but in terms of my girlfriend, she grew up in a small village, a small town in [Town's Name] and of course with more pressure. She has more reservations now.

Speaker 1 [00:23:02] It came again just now, yes

Speaker 2 [00:23:06] Where have you been?

Speaker 1 [00:23:02] You were saying it is growing with more pressure.

Speaker 2 [00:23:09] Yes, exactly. Because she grows up with more pressure, I sense this in her. She doesn't want people to hear too much. Not the people who are close to her own circle, our friends, not the people we are close to. Only people from her hometown. Because there are a lot of

people in [City], I mean, there are definitely acquaintances somewhere around. She doesn't want them to hear or know much anyway. Of course her family doesn't have the means, she doesn't want to open up to them anyway. She has such a reservation, but I mean, for example, what I heard from her is that you are the one I live most comfortably with, because my partners were not as open-minded as you, so we were living with more pressure. But now we are more normal, that is, we don't have any behavior like kissing or excessive contact outside like a hetero couple. But this is not something I normally like very much anyway. A little bit because of such etiquette. But for example, we walk hand in hand in places where we are comfortable, for example, there has been no one who has been very strange about this outside or who has understood that we are a couple and has made any hate speech or behavior towards us, frankly, until today. But of course, this is also related to the fact that the places we live in are more modern places. I am sure that if we held hands somewhere in a district of [City]. Maybe yes, this will be weird, but I mean, my experiences like this, to be honest, I haven't experienced anything very bad, and I hope I won't experience it for the rest of my life. But while my family may be more open-minded on this issue, I think her family is more conservative on this issue.

Speaker 1 [00:24:59] Well, for example, do you see the reflection of both the conservatism of your partner's family and this social pressure on the relationship? Or do you think it reflects on this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:25:14] I mean, of course I have this feeling. That one day this relationship will never be formalized. Unless we get citizenship from a country like [Country ] or [Country B], there's a strange feeling because of that. Yes, I think I am at a very young age to get married. She's [1-5] years older than me, but no matter what, if there was a man in such a relationship, I would definitely want to make it official. Not now, but in [1-5] years, I would want to. There's a bitterness in me knowing that it's not going to happen. But of course, on the other hand, I also think, what's going on? Marriage is not just about signing a contract and doing what you want. Sharing the same house, sharing the same life also opens the same door at some point. I mean, it has such a reflection, I think that's why this happens, we can be more comfortable in the relationship because I have seen it from my friends. When couples think that a hetero relationship that I have experienced myself will lead to marriage, they start to pay extreme attention to their behavior. They try to behave much more, what should I call it, they try to behave more soberly. They don't do the crazier things they would normally do because they think that the person in front of me is a person I want to spend my life with and I should draw a proper profile for him. Because they think there will be a formality at the end. But in our relationship, for example, there is no such thing. I mean, I never have to worry about the formal part of it. Or according to some of my friends, we have been together for how many years, I send all the signals for when she is going to propose. But I don't have anything like that and I think this makes me more comfortable in the relationship. I can say my thoughts more easily, I can exhibit some of the things I want to do more easily, I can behave more comfortably. She can even exhibit my behavior that I know does not suit her. Because at some point, I mean, it's not the end of the world. We might break up at some point. But there is this pressure of marriage because we are in [Country C], I should always draw a perfect profile with people, we should draw

a perfect profile in her family. There is such an attitude, but there is no such thing in our relationship, for example.

Speaker 1 [00:27:32] So, for example, do you think that this lack of marriage pressure is a factor that increases the quality of your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:27:39] I don't think it increases or decreases because there are pros and cons. So should I explain my opinion? Or is this answer enough?

Speaker 1 [00:27:47] Can you please explain?

Speaker 2 [00:27:49] The con is of course the issue of commitment, because as I just mentioned, it's not the end of the world, there is of course the sloppiness of saying that we can be apart at some point. Because well, you know. Even if I do something bad, even if the other side does it, at some point we can say that we can turn around and leave. But there is also the comfort of not being under such a pressure. We are people who want to live our youth to the fullest and like our friends, we want to find a decent job as soon as possible, find a job with insurance, get a good job, get a car, and then propose to our girlfriend. You know, guys have this, or girls have such concerns like I shouldn't go to nightclubs so much anymore, I should pay attention to how I look on social media, I should draw a proper profile with the family, but the lack of this in our relationship makes us a more cheerful couple. We can experience something more enthusiastic. Because our goal in our relationship is never to become husband and wife and start a family, but to have a very good relationship and share life and be happy. I apologize very much, the door rang for a second.

Speaker 1 [00:29:17] Yes yes.

Speaker 2 [00:29:27] I am very sorry, such things happen in online interviews. So we are not concerned about drawing such a profile. Our relationship is our first priority. First of all, we want to be best friends. That's our difference. I mean, there are cons on the one hand and pros on the other, but I think it doesn't change the quality much.

Speaker 1 [00:29:51] So what would you say are the difficulties in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:29:55] Don't break anymore.

Speaker 1 [00:29:58] Can you hear it now?

Speaker 2 [00:30:00] Yes, yes.

Speaker 1 [00:30:01] So what would you say are the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:30:12] I mean personally or the challenges of being in a same-sex relationship?

Speaker 1 [00:30:16] Personally?

Speaker 2 [00:30:20] Personally, How can I say? First of all, [redacted]. Also, I admire her because she has a workshop she established at a very young age and she has about [10-15] employees there but of course there are also difficulties. There are too many of them and too many people are responsible. There is a huge work responsibility. Of course there are some stress factors from there. On the other hand, my life is much more comfortable. Because I am still thinking of continuing my education and there are stresses there too. But I'm doing sports right now, so I'm very comfortable. My only problem is something like the weather is bad or something like that. We have such difficulties economically or socially.

Speaker 1 [00:31:42] So are there any difficulties you would like to add to a homosexual relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:31:48] I mean, sometimes of course there can be a disadvantage of being two women. We women talk much longer, men are more like OK, we'll take care of it, we'll see, they can cut it off completely. And sometimes talking about a very long topic becomes too long and boring. I mean, both sides express their opinions for a long time. I think it has such difficulty, but it's not a big minus for me.

Speaker 1 [00:32:23] So do you and your partner fight?

Speaker 2 [00:32:28] I mean yes, not very often, but probably once a month or something.

Speaker 1 [00:32:37] And what are these fights usually about?

Speaker 2 [00:32:42] Usually it's about her not listening to me like I just mentioned. I'm explaining something and she interrupts or I'm explaining something, someone comes in and interrupts her and interrupts me and then turns directly to her. Then the person turns back to me and says, "Uh oh, I'm sorry I interrupted you. But I get very angry because I have a very nervous nature. I mean, I'm usually the cause anyway, most of our arguments are usually about not listening, or even if there is a misunderstanding, she doesn't listen when I explain it. But again, it always comes back to not listening.

Speaker 1 [00:33:22] So how do you solve these fights?

Speaker 2 [00:33:27] I mean, the first one like this is a big fight, more like this, where the voice and the pulse gets louder. But it's short. I mean it lasts like 3 or 4 minutes. Then we try to stay in a bit of a routine. We continue our communication, but not as close as we normally are. When a day or so passes like that, we both get tired of this coldness and sit down and talk calmly. Yes, just talk now, ok, we calmed down, what I was angry about, I was nervous about this, this happened, it is usually solved like this

Speaker 1 [00:34:04] So apart from this calm conversation, what do you think are the other ways to maintain your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:34:11] What do you mean?

Speaker 1 [00:34:13] Like what do you think are the ways to maintain a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:34:19] You mean after a fight?

Speaker 1 [00:34:21] No, the ways to maintain a relationship in general.

Speaker 2 [00:34:26] I mean. It could be that there is a common purpose in the relationship. So partners may be in business together or they may have a child or a pet or they may share a house. So they may feel obliged to stay in a relationship. So these things can happen.

Speaker 1 [00:34:47] So for your own relationship in the context of your own relationship in what ways do you think you maintain your own relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:35:00] I mean I'm going to sneeze for a second, I think traveling is something that sustains our relationship. Going somewhere and going out to eat, for example, is an activity. I mean, it's always based on activity. I mean, let's go to this place on Tuesday, let's do this on Wednesday, let's do this on Thursday. Continuing an activity or a hobby is sustaining for us in a relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:35:30] So would you say that this relationship is good for you?

Speaker 2 [00:35:34] Yes, it's good for sure. It's good for me.

Speaker 1 [00:35:38] Do you want to elaborate a little bit on why you think that?

Speaker 2 [00:35:41] Sure, I mean. A lot in life. How shall I put it? I was in a period when I was feeling lonely and I was actually around a lot of people that I was flirting with, but I couldn't keep it going, I mean, the cons always outweighed and somehow it would end. Or there was distance. Something was happening. It just wasn't happening. But then this relationship started and my feeling of loneliness really went away for once. I mean, I could feel it because even in some of my relationships I felt lonely when there was someone with me. But now I feel that there is someone I can trust. It makes me happy to have someone who will be with me when I'm alone or who can come with me even when I want to go somewhere. It's good for me in that respect. Other than that, I am not a person who can provide a lot of internal motivation and I need something external like that. At those times, my girlfriend had a great influence. Because for example, I need to study for IELTS. She opens my IELTS book and gives me homework, like "do this, do that." Things like that are good for me or take me to study. The things I need to do, well, it's a driving force for me on the one hand, it's good from that point of view. And nowadays, I was in a process where I was questioning my life ideals. I really didn't know what I wanted to do in life. I always tried to do [University], but I was more or less questioning whether I really wanted it, whether it would offer me the life I wanted. But it was also very difficult to get into business life and I entered a process that I touched like this. I couldn't do anything and I was experiencing a lot of anxiety. But having a relationship gave me this motivation. She has a job that pays good money and is enough to build a life and I should do the same so that we can build a future together. For example, we can buy a new house. I mean, a house is a much more realistic dream for a young person right now. But at least it was very good for me to have a relationship that I work for, a relationship that I strive for in life.

Speaker 1 [00:37:57] So did this relationship change you?

Speaker 2 [00:38:02] Yes, actually it changed me a lot. I realized that before this relationship I was very incredibly selfish, first of all, and in my past relationships the other party was not making any sacrifices for the other party. In my relationships, I was always expected to be taken care of and for a relationship to revolve around me. I had a huge dependency on my friends and I had a role confusion with my friends. At times, I was putting them as my partner, you know, calling them immediately when I buy something. Trying to reach them when I was in a difficult situation even though I knew they were not available, or telling my friends even when there was a family situation. These are actually things that I consider more normal to experience with such partners. But I got into such a role confusion with my friends. I was expecting a more relationship-like ownership from them. This has also disappeared. I'm sure there are many things that have changed, but maybe I didn't realize it.

Speaker 1 [00:39:08] And do you think your partner changed during the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:39:14] I don't think so. I mean, when we started our relationship, she had just finished a long relationship. But how can I say that? I mean she has a very beautiful personality which can be very approved by the society. I mean, she is a person who is incredibly loved wherever she goes, worshiped, so to speak, by everyone she meets. Because she has very high social skills, and morally, I don't know, in terms of personality traits, she has a lot of positive things. That's why I don't think she has changed with me, but of course we are older. [1-5] years is not a big difference, but when we look at the periods of our lives, I graduated from [University] in [Month]. She had already studied a [1-5] program and she was [1-5] years and [1-5] years older than me before I graduated. Before I graduated, she had already graduated [1-5] years ago, worked in many, many places, established her own business, and has employees under her. So, even though our difference in age is actually small, there is a huge difference in terms of life period. So I don't think I contributed to her personality development or change. I mean, I can say that she contributed more to mine.

Speaker 1 [00:40:35] Well, for example, you said that your partner has very good personality traits. Can you give examples of that? Or what kind of personality traits do you think especially enhance the quality of your own relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:40:48] Well, first of all, I think incredibly pleasant conversations are very important. I mean, she can always talk about different topics with very different people. But not in a pedantic way, she can be very interested in a subject she doesn't know anything about and ask a lot of questions about it, and this allows her to talk about any subject and to communicate very easily with the people I bring together. Besides that, she can be the most helpful person I have ever seen in my life. I mean, they say that no matter how tired she is, she will come. She is such a person,

she really tries to help everyone. There are even points where she sometimes exaggerates this. I mean, she can't spare time for herself, but she does something for others. This is something that makes her incredibly special anyway. Other than that, I mean, how can I say, being humorous is a very nice feature for me. Because she is a very charming person, even in a very bad situation, she makes funny jokes without offending or hurting you so much that you suddenly realize that you are laughing at your own pitiful state. I mean, I'm not talking about death or anything like that, but we can show people the anxiety. She can easily show with her jokes that the things we worry about are not as important as we think. When I observe that she is like this to me and to everyone around us, my interest in her increases even more. I mean, I like this situation more. I guess these are the basics.

Speaker 1 [00:42:25] Well, for example, you just said that when she is like this around, you know, her interest in you increases, directly at the beginning of your first book, I said that it attracted your attention that she was very popular and attracted attention around, for example. Can you elaborate on this part? How did his being such a beloved character affect your relationship at the beginning of your relationship or during your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:42:53] I mean me. I don't really care what other people think about. I've never been one of those other people. I don't think it's the people who say that. Because people are not like that. Because as human beings we are very social and we're always making ideas out of other people's reflections, you know. I admitted it to myself, yes, what people around me think is really important to me. So if different people don't like it, it increases my interest, desire and love more. It has such a side. I also like to be in crowded environments because I have a very small family and it was very boring. We didn't always live in the same city as our relatives and that family was not an area where I could experience the feeling of belonging, but I was able to experience this at university. Luckily, I met very good people and I had a really nice environment. So it is very enjoyable for me to spend time with them. It feels like I'm fulfilling a part of me that is half a child inside me, and it was very important for me that my partner could adapt to this environment so well and make that environment even more beautiful than it was. That's why people's opinions are so important to me.

Speaker 1 [00:44:10] So do you feel safe in this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:44:14] Yes, I feel completely safe, I mean, no cheating. I don't have any fear of being cheated on or abandoned, I honestly don't have such a thought. I mean, it's very interesting, but I have such a 100% feeling of trust.

Speaker 1 [00:44:30] Could you explain a little bit more why you think like this?



Speaker 2 [00:44:36] I mean, first of all, [Patner's Name] is incredibly committed to monogamy. I mean, even the fact that some people flirt with more than one person sometimes seems strange to her. That's why I don't think that she will progress to a very different type of partner when she is with me. Besides that, even if the romantic feelings between us decrease, I think that she will still provide me with that trust space for the sake of the time we spend with her and the fact that we are two people who care about each other and two people who give. So I honestly don't think that she will create any situation that will break my trust or leave me in the middle.

Speaker 1 [00:45:22] now I'm going to share a screen with you. If I ask you my partner usually really listens to me, that's not true at all. Nine is completely true. What would you give on the scale range?

Speaker 2 [00:45:40] 4.

Speaker 1 [00:45:44] 4. And if I asked you that my partner is usually sensitive to my needs? Again, not true. Nine is completely true. What would you give on the scale range?

Speaker 2 [00:45:53] 8.

Speaker 1 [00:45:55] 8. Why did you answer 4 to your first item that my partner usually really listens to me?

Speaker 2 [00:46:08] Well, because of her lack of attention, obviously, not because she doesn't want to do it, even if she forces herself. For example, I want to talk about something I'm worried about in life in a long way, but I know that she gets disconnected at some point and at that time her head is thinking about something related to work and then she catches up towards the end and she only has an idea about the subject but she doesn't keep the details in her mind, so I know that.

Speaker 1 [00:46:46] So can you give concrete examples of when this happens? Of these.

Speaker 2 [00:46:54] I mean the days when she gets off work late. I can say the evening hours on weekdays because her energy is exhausted. Weekends are more energetic.

Speaker 1 [00:47:08] So why did you answer four and not three or five?

Speaker 2 [00:47:15] I mean 5. It seemed like a very, how shall I say, normal thing that can happen with other couples. I think the biggest problem that a woman can declare in a relationship is that she never listens to me. But our situation is a little more serious than that, but not as low as three. So 4 seemed less sympathetic to me.

Speaker 1 [00:47:39] Okay. The other item is that my partner is usually sensitive to my needs. Can I ask you why you answered 8?

Speaker 2 [00:47:51] I mean. Because when I express something that I need or when it's obvious. For example, let's say she came home, I was hungry or there was no coffee at home, whatever happens the next day, for example, she comes with coffee in her hand, and this is emotionally like that, for example, in a situation where she realizes that we are upset or in a situation that I have expressed, she does her best to share that feeling and then to make it more positive. I mean, she tells me about a favorite dish. She sits and talks to me for a long time, spares time for me, does things like that, or other than that. For example, I've been on a plane maybe [50-55] times in a year, I had to travel a lot. And I have never gone to the airport alone, for example, she would take me in [City], you know, she would leave work, drop me off and come back. I mean, she is very attentive to my needs like this, she tries to find a solution immediately. That's why.

Speaker 1 [00:48:54] So why did you answer eight and not seven or nine?

Speaker 2 [00:49:01] 9 seemed to me a little bit like a relationship that turned into a very pathological parental relationship. You know, she became more of a mother or a father. We are not that much, of course, I solve some things myself, but besides that, when I look at the people around me, I try to make a comparison. 8 is a number I can give because she shows a much higher interest than other lovers.

Speaker 1 [00:49:32] I hope you don't mind asking this and if it's too sensitive for you to share please feel free to say so. But I also want to know about your physical makeup as a couple, how often do you have sexual intercourse these days?

Speaker 2 [00:49:50] Once a week, I guess.

Speaker 1 [00:49:53] And how satisfied are you with your sex life?

Speaker 2 [00:49:59] I would say 7 out of 10.

Speaker 1 [00:50:03] Would you like to explain why you say that?

Speaker 2 [00:50:08] First of all, homosexuality is still a very foreign subject for me. It's very... Yes, I spent [1-5] year, but before that I spent a long time with men, so having a relationship with a woman's body. There's still a lot of things that I don't know how to do or how to say I'm not good at. The female body really requires a little bit more fineness for me. There are things like that. There are points that I see a little inadequate in myself. Other than that, I would like to have sex more often. I'm actually deducting some more points because we haven't had it. Because she has been working very hard for [1-5] months or so and the time we spend at home is very limited and at night, for example, she falls asleep, I mean really, or I fall asleep sometimes. So we have such a thing, we have less sexual intercourse than we normally have, so that's why.

Speaker 1 [00:51:11] So how important do you think sexuality is in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:51:18] I would like to give a slightly different answer here. It is definitely very important, but I think sexuality is very important, not as a physical union where both parties have an orgasm, but I think it is very important to be in physical contact. I mean, holding hands, hugging, sitting and...

Speaker 1 [00:52:10] Can you hear me right now?

Speaker 2 [00:52:11] Yes yes

Speaker 1 [00:52:13] Last time we were at the holding hands part.

Speaker 2 [00:52:16] Yes, yes. I mean, I think it's more important for me to have physical intimacy, physical contact and to be able to have that contact in a comfortable way and to enjoy that contact rather than to have sex and to have an orgasm. So rather than necessarily having an orgasm.

Speaker 1 [00:52:37] Now I'm going to share a screen with you again and if I ask you how satisfied you are in your relationship in general, which of the following options would you prefer?

Speaker 2 [00:52:50] I would say very satisfied.

Speaker 1 [00:52:53] And if I ask you how would you rate your satisfaction in your relationship? 0 Not satisfied at all, completely satisfied. What would you choose on the scale?

Speaker 2 [00:53:04] Very similar things, 8. Or 9.

Speaker 1 [00:53:08] 9 Okay. Can I ask you why you answered 9?

Speaker 2 [00:53:19] So for me it has to be a perfect relationship to be completely satisfied. I don't believe that there is such a thing as a perfect relationship. Every person is very different from each other and there is always something unpleasant. Things like what I just mentioned. Some problems with word communication. They put me behind, but other than that, because I am very satisfied with the time we spend together, her interest in me, or the interest I show, it is close to complete, but because it sounds very utopian, one point lower than that, it makes more sense to me.

Speaker 1 [00:53:59] So do you think this relationship met your expectations?

Speaker 2 [00:54:06] Yes, to a very large extent, to be honest. Just when I think about it like this, for example, how can I say that two women in a relationship? For example, I was always thinking like this. I'm a normal woman who goes to the hairdresser with my friend. I mean, I'm not a very masculine woman, I'm more on the feminine side. Sometimes we go for a manicure, for example, and this is very enjoyable for us when we are in a relationship with a woman. I thought that was the case, but I overlooked the fact that a woman I would probably have a relationship with would be much more masculine and would not be interested in such things. But for some reason, I never thought of it that way, so [Partner's Name] has no interest in such things. I mean, even if she is interested, she can't spare time for it. I mean, yes, she needs to go to the hairdresser, but someone says let's have coffee, okay, the hairdresser is canceled. It doesn't have a great personal importance for her, so the lack of such things actually made me a little sad because that has excited me a lot at the beginning. Or that we were watching a stupid romantic comedy movie together and I know it's all typical female traits right now, but there's nothing to do. I'm a typical woman, I mean, when we watch it and we think we're going to be very emotional or excited at the end, she reacts in a more masculine way and says what the hell is this, but I find it romantic and very beautiful. There were such differences, to be honest. You know, these did not meet my expectations, but other than that, I guess there is not much I can say that I was expecting but it didn't happen.

Speaker 1 [00:55:38] Well, for example, do you think that these processes reduce the quality of your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:55:44] Honestly, I don't think so. I can even say that maybe it even increases it a little bit. Because I define myself as bisexual. But is there a need to define it? You know, I was always interested in men until today and a woman's relationship with a man was always more normalized in my mind. The man is calmer, what can you call it, more masculine, he's always like that, and the woman is more chirpy, more talkative, more expressive. I had such a normal in my head, and when I look at it, [Partner Name]'s masculine behavior actually ticks this, so I can say that it more conformed to my expectations and raised its quality more.

Speaker 1 [00:56:31] We are about to finish the episode, but I would like to summarize what we talked about in the last hour, if you allow me, we started with demographic questions first, both to confirm the accuracy and to add if there is anything you want to add. You said that you are [20-25] years old, you have been with your partner for [1-5] years, and you live alone at home. Tell us the story of when you met on [Social Media]. You had been following each other for a long time. Then you messaged as friends and after [<1 year] you started flirting. You talked about the importance of being two women here and having a different kind of empathy, that you have a better quality relationship compared to your friends' relationships. Compared to your past relationships, you again said that you have better quality. You mentioned that it is important to spend more quality time, to have sex when both parties want to have sex, to share your interests. When we asked about the qualities that make a relationship of high quality for you, you stated that it is important that communication is healthy, that it is not toxic, that the same topic is not discussed 45 times and that the time spent together is voluntary. Again, when we asked about the most important things in it for you, you mentioned the importance of communication and being able to spend time together, being there for each other in good and difficult times in each other's lives. When we asked what love is for you, you mentioned the importance of being able to position a person between friends and family and said that love is seventy percent important in a relationship. You said that you know you love your partner when he/she makes sacrifices, when he/she does things that usually make you happy. You said that you have a fight once a month and that it is usually about not listening, about being divided, which is then resolved by talking calmly afterwards. You talked about the importance of having a common goal and doing activities together to maintain the relationship. You said that this relationship was good for you because at a time in your life when you were feeling very lonely, you wanted the presence of a person you could trust and you also said that this relationship changed you but not your partner. Here again, we talked about collaborations such as your partner being helpful and being liked in environments. Then you said that you feel safe in this job. When I asked if your partner usually listens to me, there are four answers. You said that this is usually due to a lack of attention. You answered 8, saying that your partner is usually sensitive to your needs. You said that you have sex once a week, that you are seven out of 10 satisfied with sex, and that the points where you are offended are because you want to have more sex. But you said that the importance of sexuality is physical contact rather than sex, holding

hands, hugging. You said that you were satisfied with the nine degrees in the relationship because you said that there is no perfect relationship and you also said that your expectations were largely met. Was there any part that you would like to add or change?

Speaker 2 [00:59:58] No, it's all true, but she will never admit that I was messaging her on Instagram as a friend at first. She always thinks that I sent it to flirt with her, but I sent it as a friend. No, I mean, apart from that, no, well, it's all true.

Speaker 1 [01:00:13] Anyway, all your information is confidential and we don't tell you anything about any meeting at your party and you can be sure of that. Before we finish as a question, I would like to talk to you about how we will handle the data because as a research project we want to be as transparent as ethically possible and therefore we would like to know which data sharing option is most suitable for you. The first option is to share parts of this transcript of our interview. None of these transcripts will contain any information that can identify you. This way, our de-identified combined interview transcript can be read by other researchers. The second option, if you don't mind and if you want to be a little more daring, is to share the entire interview transcript anonymized and stripped of sensitive and overly identifying details. In this option, there is a slim chance that someone who knows you well will be able to piece together the details of the interview transcript and narrow down the choices among their colleagues as to who they believe you are. But again, I want to emphasize that no sensitive information will be shared. All your information will remain anonymous. Which of these two options do you prefer?

Speaker 2 [01:01:26] You can share all of it, I have no problem with that.

Speaker 1 [01:01:29] Okay.

Speaker 2 [01:01:30] So everyone can share anonymously.

Speaker 1 [01:01:33] Okay, thank you very much again for participating. We believe that your answers are very valuable to this project from your point of view, we believe that this project is a cross-cultural project with other countries like the Netherlands, France, America. Can you hear me now, can you hear me now?

Speaker 2 [01:02:06] Yes, yes, yes, everyone, you can share everything anonymously, it's not a problem for me. Whatever it needs to be.

Speaker 1 [01:02:12] Again, thank you very much for participating in this study. I would like you to know that this study has also been conducted in the Philippines, Brazil, the Netherlands, France and the United States. I believe that your viewpoints and perspectives will be very valuable for the project. Finally, after this interview, I will share a questionnaire with you. It is a questionnaire that takes a maximum of 10 minutes and I will ask you to fill out this questionnaire with a code in the section that asks for your name. In this way, all your data will be stored anonymously. Once again, thank you very much and I hope it was enjoyable for you as well. It was a very pleasant and productive interview for me. Thank you very much. I wish you happiness in your relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:02:51] Good luck. Good evening.

Speaker 1 [01:02:53] Thank you.